Manohar Parrikar who died in office in March 2019. Parrikar, who served as Union Defence Minister from 2014 to 2017 and four terms as Chief Minister was awarded the Padma Bhushan posthumously last year.

Modi said, "When I see the achievements of Goa, this new identity being strengthened, I remember my friend Manohar Parrikarji. He not only took Goa to new heights of development, but also expanded Goa's potential. How can one remain devoted to his state, his people, till his last breath? We saw this in his life." The nation, he added, saw the reflection of the honesty, talent and diligence of the people of Goa in Parrikar.

They then proceeded to the spectacular Miramar beach where he watched the Indian Navy's fly past and sail parade.

INDIA'S BEST PERFORMING SMALL STATE

For the third year running, Goa was named India Today's Small States Winner, outperforming other contenders particularly in economy, tourism and infrastructure.

Despite being hit by the ban on mining in 2012, the economic survey of 2019-20 showed excellent promise in terms of per capita income, flow of foreign direct investment and a boost in infrastructure.

Its gross state domestic product (GSDP) growth in 2017-18 was up 12.14 per cent over the previous fiscal. Infrastructure has been boosted across the state including the new Atal Setu bridge over river Mandovi, a new bridge over the river Zuari, the Greenfield International Airport at Mopa, a four-lane road reducing traffic burden to an industrial corporation in South Goa and a new high court complex.

In addition, funds are being pumped in for the development of an electronic hub at Tuem in North Goa even as bridges in multiple locations across the state have been reconstructed to improve connectivity. As part of the Swachh Bharat, Nitol Goem mission, the government has worked towards 100 per cent door-to-door waste collection across Goa with a segregation success rate of 86 per cent in 14 urban local bodies.

A PROMISING INVESTMENT DESTINATION

Goa has borne the title of a state of sunshine and the good life ever since liberation. The government has been consistently working to add new dimensions to its revenue, other than the golden goose of tourism. The overall aim has been to turn Goa into an investment destination in order to boost employment and alternate industries in-house.

Over the last few years, the government has promoted entrepreneurship and sustainable businesses; launched numerous start-up initiatives including iMagic (S4S)3, WE-nurture and RIVER; inaugurated an incubation centre to attract investment for Goa-based start ups; and facilitate entrepreneurship as an alternate career option through Goa Institute of Management's Atal Incubation Centre.



Chief Minister Dr Pramod Sawant Inaugurating the Start-Up Conclave & Entrepreneurship Summit "Antha Prerna"

Dr Pramod Sawant's vision is to 'retain Goans in Goa' by promoting opportunities and facilitating the employment eco-system. One of these is through Antha Prerna, a startup conclave and entrepreneurship summit.

As much as Rs 1.27 crores were pumped in as of April 2019 to give certified startups a financial boost. The Start-Up India Global Venture Capital Summit was also organised in Goa to mobilise global capital for innovations in the country. To support this, a new telecom infrastructure policy was introduced in 2020 to improve network connectivity for the benefit of all sections of society including tech startups, IT professionals, students, etc.

The Ignite Innovation hub at the Economic Development Corporation Ltd achieved 100 per cent capacity from entities working in artificial intelligence, machine learning, Internet of Things, smart building solutions, renewable energy, 3D printing and more.

Dr Pramod Sawant has said, "Goa has a favourable business environment. We are making policies to make Goa attractive for investors and tourists. The Investment Promotion Board will now take clearances from all departments within a fixed time frame of 15 days."

THE FIGHT AGAINST COVID-19

As a tourist state, Goa found itself struggling against the onslaught of COVID-19.

With developing countries frantically waiting for vaccines, Goa joined the country in attempting to immunise as much of its population as fast as possible, beginning with the most important and most vulnerable sections of society.

As vaccine stocks became more freely available, the state government organised 'Tika Utsav' at multiple locations to encourage the citizens to come forward and receive vaccinations at public and private centres.

State immunisation officer Dr Rajendra Borkar said, "From March 2021, all eligible people were being vaccinated free of cost across all 42 government COVID-19 vaccination centres and 198 satellite centres via government health centres, and 27 private hospitals."

In September 2021, Prime Minister Modi extended his congratulations to the state for being the first in India to administer the first dose of the vaccine to 100 per cent of its eligible population. Chief Minister Dr Sawant has said that the government aims to declare Goa a Corona virus-free state 'as soon as possible'.

PROMOTING TRADITIONAL OCCUPATIONS

Agriculture and fishing are two of Goa's traditional occupations. Major crops include rice, coconut, cashew, sugarcane, pineapple, banana and mango. Processing of many of these crops are done in neighbouring states, and the government